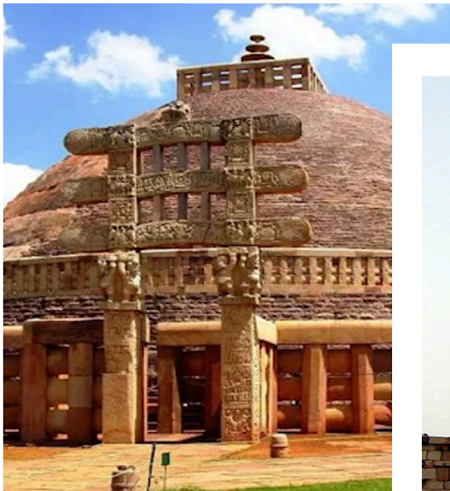


General Knowledge

Ancient History

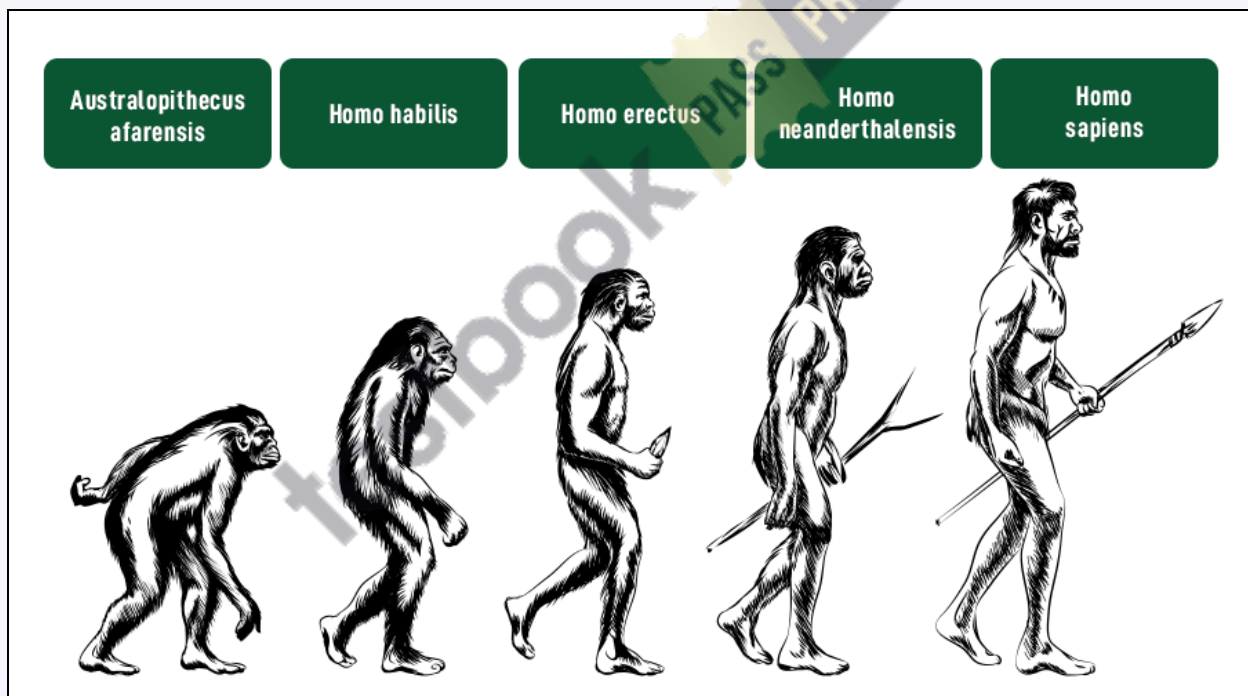
STUDY NOTES

Stone Age



Human Evolution

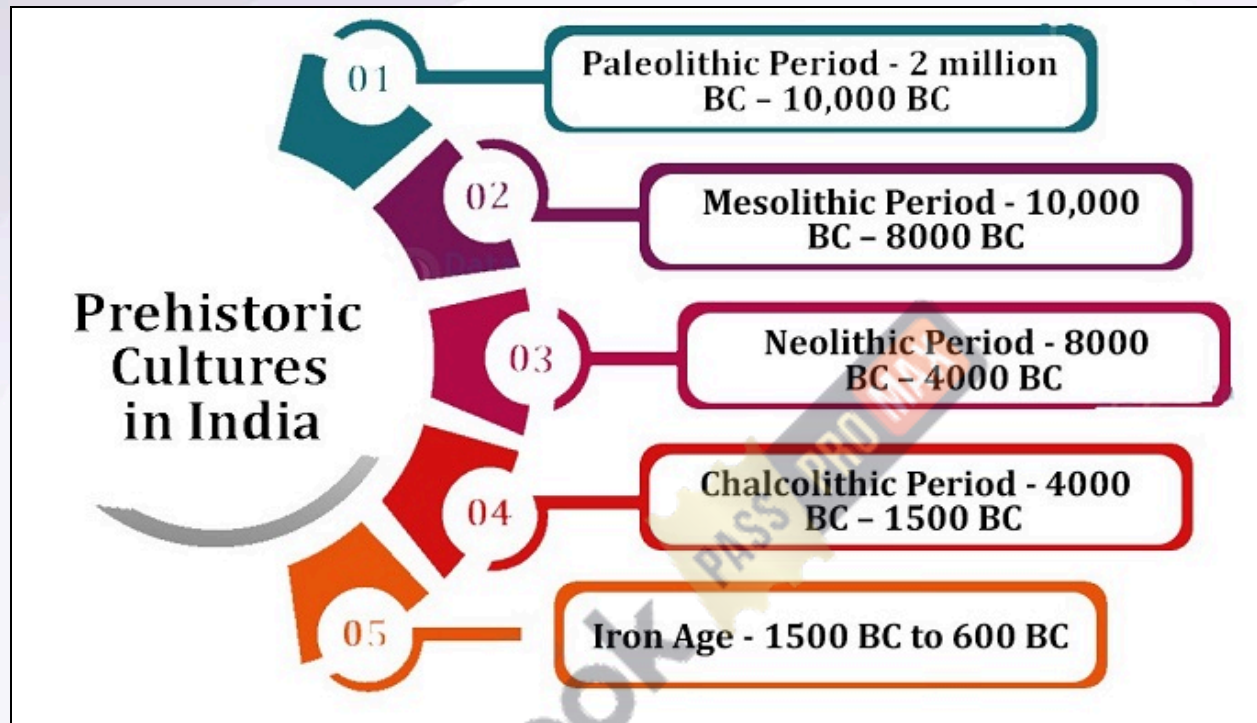
- **Human evolution** traces the development of humans on Earth, starting with the earliest fossil evidence dating back **3.7 billion years**.
- **Australopithecus**, a group of **hominins**, lived from **4.4 million to 1.4 million years ago**, and are regarded as close ancestors of modern humans.
- **Homo habilis**: Regarded as the earliest member of the **genus Homo**, it lived in parts of **sub-Saharan Africa** between **2 to 1.5 million years ago**.
- The first fossil of **Homo erectus**, the **missing link** between humans and apes, was discovered on **Java Island in 1891**.



- **Homo sapiens neanderthalensis** (Neanderthal man): Their fossils were first discovered in **Germany in 1856**. They are a part of the **Homo sapiens** family.
- **Homo sapiens**: The modern upright-walking species evolved in **Africa around 315,000 years ago**.
- The oldest **modern Homo sapiens sapiens** fossils were found at **Cro-Magnon, France**, dating back **100,000 to 125,000 B.P. years**.

- The earliest evidence of **Homo erectus** in **India** was found in the **Narmada Valley**, referred to as **Homo erectus narmandesis**.

Pre-Historic Period or Stone Age



- The **Stone Age** refers to a prehistoric cultural stage characterized by the creation and use of **stone tools**.
- This period began with the first appearance of **hominids** (ancestral human species of **Homo sapiens**) and extended until the **development of agriculture**.
- The **archaeological system** based on the **Stone Age** was developed by **Christian Jurgensen Thomson** in **1820**.
- The **Stone Age** is divided into three major periods:
 1. **Paleolithic Age** (Hunters and Food Gatherers up to **10,000 BC**).
 2. **Mesolithic Age** (Transition between Paleolithic and Neolithic).
 3. **Neolithic Age** (Food Producers from **4000 - 1000 BC**).

Paleolithic Age: (Up to 10,000 BC)

- The term **Palaeolithic** was introduced by **John Lubbock** in **1865** to describe the period when early humans used **stone tools** made of **Quartzite**.
- **Paleolithic people** are also referred to as **Quartzite Men**.
- This period corresponds with the **Pleistocene** or **Ice Age**.
- The **Palaeolithic Age** is categorized into three sub-periods based on **tool technology** and **climate changes**:
 1. **Lower Palaeolithic Age** (up to **100,000 BC**),
 2. **Middle Palaeolithic Age** (**100,000-40,000 BC**),
 3. **Upper Palaeolithic Age** (**40,000-10,000 BC**).
- People in this era lived by **hunting** and **food gathering** and did not know **pottery**, **agriculture**, or **metals**.



Prominent Archaeologists in Pre-Historical Studies in India

- **Sir Alexander Cunningham**: First **Director** of the **Archaeological Survey of India** in **AD 1861**, played a pivotal role in discovering **Palaeolithic sites**.
- **Robert Bruce Foote**: Known as the **Father of Indian Pre-history**, he discovered the **Pallavaram Hand Axe** and made major contributions to pre-historic studies.

The Lower Palaeolithic Age (Up to 100,000 BC)

- The **Lower Palaeolithic Age** is characterized by tools such as **hand axes**, **cleavers**, **choppers**, and **chopping tools**.
- These early humans lived by **foraging**, **hunting**, and **fishing**.
- No evidence of **burials** was found, and they constructed **shelters** using materials like **tree branches**, **leaves**, and **stones**.

Sites

Site	Area
Belan Valley	Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh
Bhimbetka	Madhya Pradesh
Jogdaha	Madhya Pradesh
Bagor	Rajasthan
Budha Pushkar	Rajasthan
Patne	Maharashtra
Nandipalle	Maharashtra
Renugunta	Andhra Pradesh
Kurnool Caves	Andhra Pradesh
Singhbhum	Jharkhand
Sohan Valley	West Punjab (Pakistan)

The Middle Palaeolithic Age (100,000–40,000 BC)

- **Tools** during this period were based on **flakes** and **pebbles**, with **blades**, **points**, and **borers** as the dominant tool types.
- People primarily engaged in **hunting**, **gathering food**, and **fishing**.
- The **Belan Valley** in **Uttar Pradesh** was rich in **stone tools** and **animal fossils** from both the **Lower** and **Middle Palaeolithic Ages**.

Middle Palaeolithic Age Sites

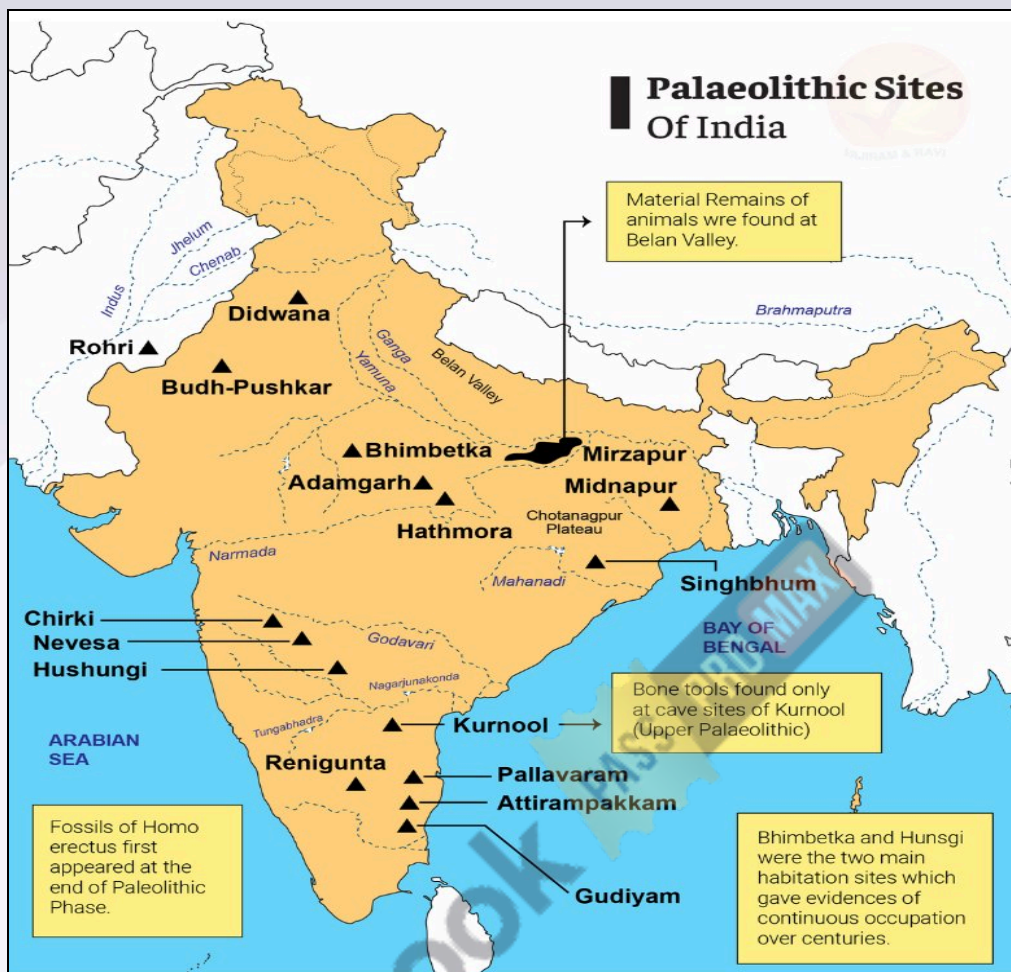
Site	State
Nevada	Maharashtra
Bhimbetka	Madhya Pradesh
Narmada Valley	Madhya Pradesh
Bagor	Rajasthan
Karmali Valley	Rajasthan
Didwana	Rajasthan
Singhbhum	Jharkhand

The Upper Palaeolithic Age (40,000-10,000 BC)

- The **Upper Palaeolithic Age** is marked by tools like **burins**, **scrapers**, and a **developed flint industry**.
- This era saw the emergence of **modern Homo sapiens** and the use of **animal resources** like **goats**, **sheep**, and **cattle** in the **Belan Valley**.
- **Bhimbetka Rock Shelter** in **Madhya Pradesh** is one of the largest prehistoric complexes and a **UNESCO World Heritage Site**.

Upper Palaeolithic Age Sites

Site	State
Kurnool Caves	Andhra Pradesh
Belan Valley	Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh
Nevasa	Maharashtra
Sabarmati Valley	Gujarat
Singrauli	Madhya Pradesh
Kichler	Andhra Pradesh
Hunsgi Valley	Karnataka
Attirampakkam	Tamil Nadu
Pahalgam	Kashmir Valley
Hathnora	Narmada Valley
Adamgarh	Madhya Pradesh



Mesolithic Age (9000-4000 BC)

- The **Mesolithic Age** marks the transition between the **Paleolithic Age** and **Neolithic Age**, spanning from **9000 BC** to **4000 BC**. It belonged to the **Holocene Era**, which began after the end of the **Pleistocene Ice Age**.
- The primary characteristic of the **Mesolithic Age** was the use of **microliths**, small, sharp stone tools that were typically about **1-2 cm** long. These tools were made from **flint** or **chert** and were used for **hunting, fishing, and gathering**.
- **Microliths** were often mounted on wooden shafts to make **spears, harpoons, and arrows**, signifying the development of more complex tools than those used in the **Paleolithic Age**.

People's Lifestyle:

- **Hunters and Gatherers:** In the early Mesolithic period, people were primarily **nomadic**, moving from one place to another in search of food.
- **Herders:** As the period progressed, they began domesticating animals like **dogs, sheep, and goats**.
- **Early Farming:** Towards the end of the Mesolithic Age, **agriculture** was beginning to emerge, although it was not as developed as in the Neolithic Age. People grew **grains** like **wheat** and **barley**.

Mesolithic Art:

- Mesolithic people were **art lovers** and created **rock paintings**.
- The **Bhimbetka** caves in **Madhya Pradesh** contain numerous examples of **Mesolithic rock art**. These paintings depicted scenes of **hunting, food gathering, dancing, and daily life**.

Domestication of Animals:

- The **Adamgarh** and **Bagor** sites show evidence of early **animal domestication**, including **cows, horses, and poultry**.
- This practice laid the foundation for **pastoralism** and **herding** in later ages.

Pottery and Settlements:

- Though **pottery** was not widespread, it began in places like **Sanganakallu** in **Karnataka**, where **handmade pottery** of **dull brown** or **black colour** was discovered.
- People in the Mesolithic Age also started to live in **semi-permanent settlements**, particularly near **rivers** and **rock shelters**.

Clothing:

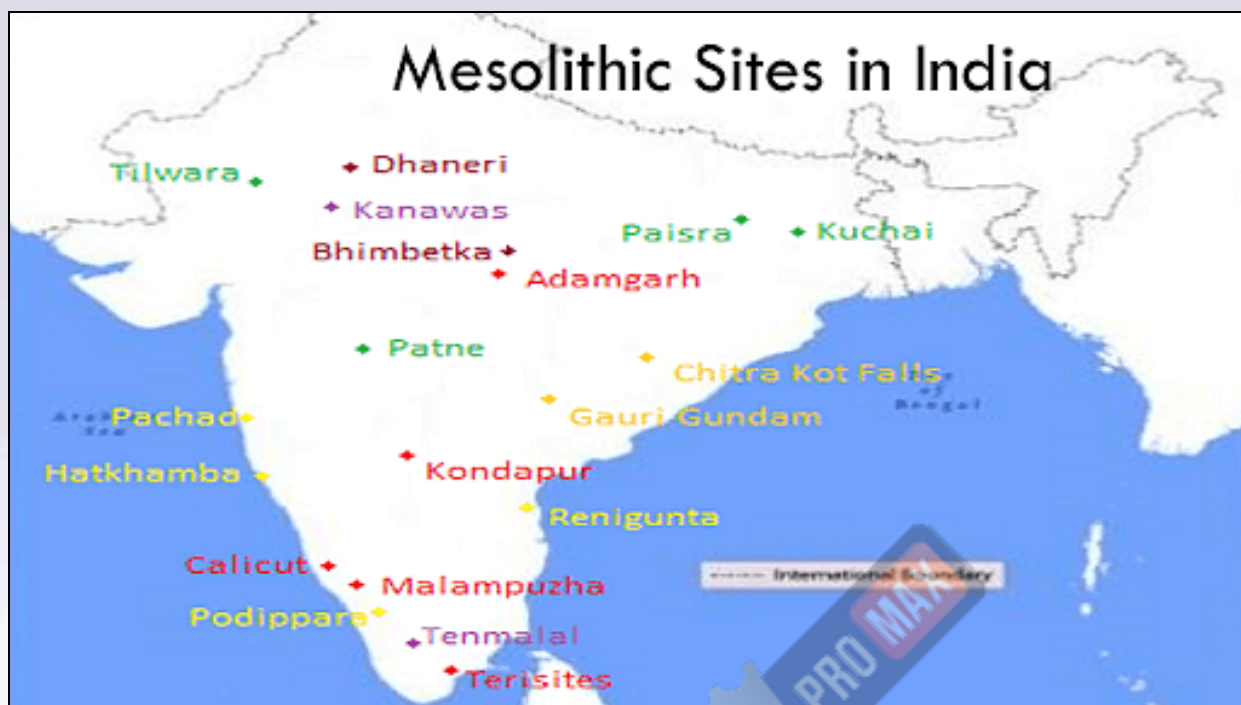
- People wore clothes made from **animal skins**, which indicates advancements in **hunting** and the use of **animal resources** for clothing.

Burial Practices:

- There is evidence of **burials** during this time. At **Damdama** in **Uttar Pradesh**, three human skeletons were found in a **single grave**, indicating early social rituals and belief systems.

Mesolithic Age Sites

Site	State
Langhnaj	Gujarat
Tilwara	Rajasthan
Bagor	Rajasthan
Patne	Maharashtra
Hatkhamba	Maharashtra
Damdama	Uttar Pradesh
Chopani Mando	Uttar Pradesh
Pachmarhi	Madhya Pradesh
Bhimbetka	Madhya Pradesh
Adamgarh	Madhya Pradesh
Sanganakallu	Karnataka
Kuchai	Odisha



Neolithic Age Food Producers (4000 -1000 BC)

- The **Neolithic Age**, also known as the **New Stone Age**, spanned from **4000 BC to 1000 BC** and marked a significant shift from a **hunter-gatherer lifestyle** to **agriculture** and **animal husbandry**.
- This age is defined by the use of **polished stone tools**, the **domestication of plants and animals**, and the establishment of **permanent settlements**.

Agriculture and Domestication:

- The key feature of the Neolithic Age was the development of **agriculture**, with people learning to **cultivate crops** such as **wheat, barley, ragi, horse gram, and cotton**.
- People began to domesticate animals like **cattle, sheep, goats, and pigs** for **food and labour**.
- **Mehrgarh**, in **Balochistan (Pakistan)**, is the **oldest known Neolithic site** in the Indian subcontinent, dating back to **7000 BC**. It provides evidence of **early agricultural practices** and **animal domestication**.



Settlements:

- Neolithic people lived in **mud-brick houses**, which were often **rectangular** or **circular**. These houses were built using **mud**, **stones**, and **reeds**, reflecting early **settled lifestyles**.
- One of the most famous Neolithic sites, **Burzahom** in **Kashmir**, reveals evidence of **pit dwellings**—houses dug into the ground, with **plastered mud walls**.

Other Developments

- **Pottery and Tools:** The Neolithic Age saw the invention of **pottery**, which was primarily **handmade** and **fire-baked**. This pottery was used for **storing grains**, **cooking**, and **water storage**. Different types of pottery emerged during this period, including **grey ware**, **black-furnished ware**, and **mat-impressed ware**.
 - **Polished stone tools** such as **axes**, **sickles**, and **blades** were used for **agricultural** and **domestic purposes**.
- **Wheel and Fire:** The invention of the **wheel** and the controlled use of **fire** are significant milestones of the **Neolithic Age**. These discoveries greatly impacted **transportation**, **cooking**, and **tool-making**.
- **Social Structure:** The surplus production of **food** led to the development of **early urban cultures** and a **settled lifestyle**. The construction of **granaries** and **storage pits** became essential to store **surplus food**.

- **Religious Beliefs:** Neolithic burials indicate that people believed in an **afterlife**. In **Burzahom**, **domestic dogs** were buried alongside humans, possibly as part of their **ritual practices**.
- **Chirand** in **Bihar** is notable for its **bone tools** and weapons, showcasing advancements in **tool-making techniques**.



Neolithic Age Sites

Site	Area
Burzahom	Kashmir
Gufkral	Kashmir
Mehrgarh	Balochistan (Pakistan)
Kili Gul Muhammad	Balochistan (Pakistan)
Daojali Hading	Assam
Chopani Mando	Uttar Pradesh
Mahagarha	Uttar Pradesh
Chirand	Bihar
Chechar	Bihar
Tekkalakota	Karnataka
Sanganakallu	Karnataka
Narsipur	Karnataka
Hallur	Karnataka
Kupgal	Karnataka
Kodekal	Karnataka
Brahmagiri	Karnataka
Nagarjunakonda	Andhra Pradesh
Piklihal	Andhra Pradesh
Utnur	Andhra Pradesh

Paiyampalli	Tamil Nadu
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Pre-Historic Art

- The **artistic expressions** during this period included **cave paintings**, **rock engravings**, and **miniature figurative carvings**.
- These artworks were made from materials readily accessible, such as **ochre**, **burnt wood**, and **cave walls**.
- **Bhimbetka** (Madhya Pradesh), **Belan Valley** (Uttar Pradesh), and **Narmada Valley** are known for **prehistoric art**, belonging to all three phases of the **Stone Age**.
- The paintings often depicted **man**, **animals**, and **geometric patterns**, with scenes showing **hunting** and **family life**.

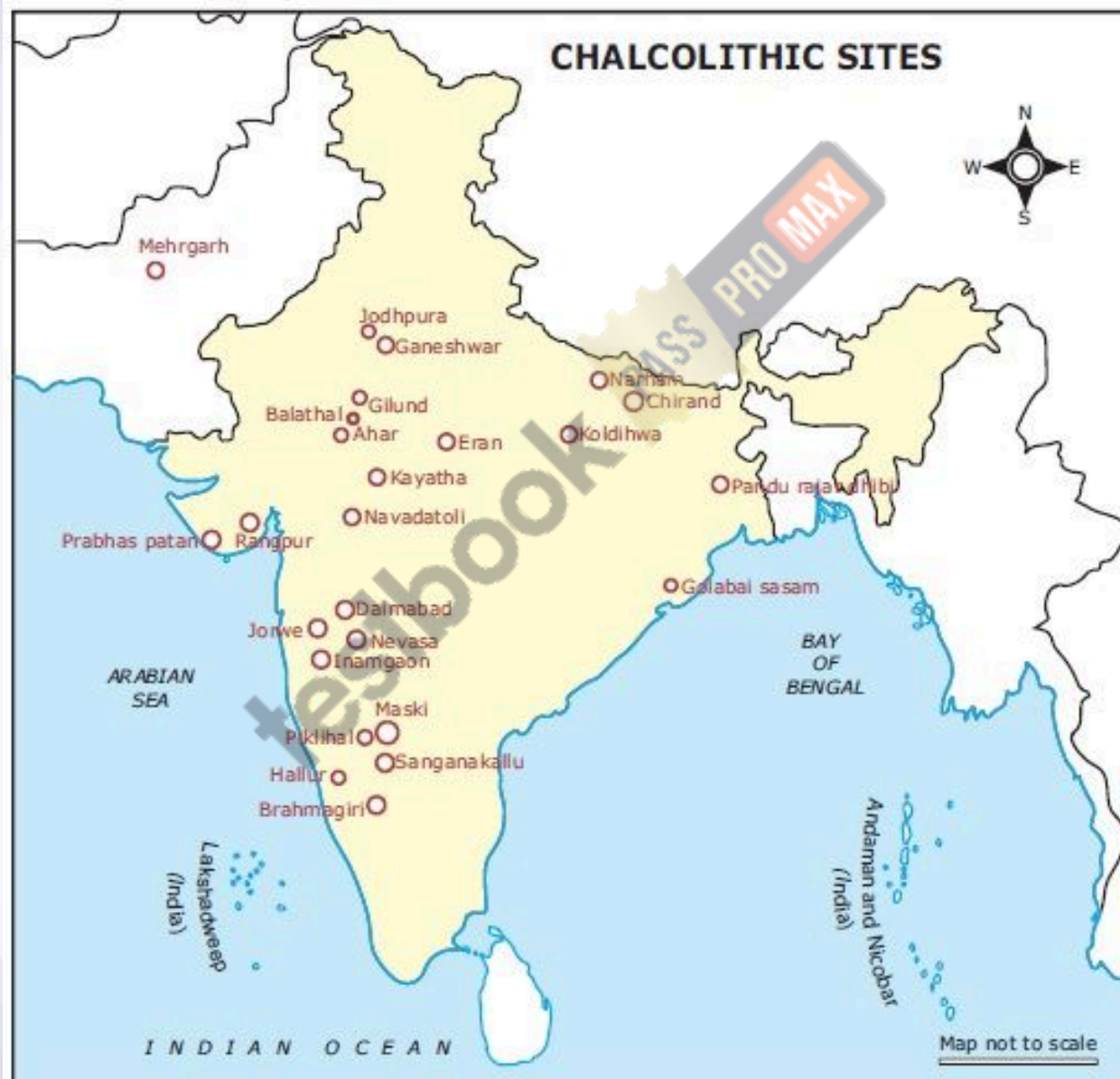
Chalcolithic Age (3500 - 1000 BC)

- The **Chalcolithic Age** marks the period when humans began using **copper** and **bronze** to make tools. It is also known as the **Copper Age**.
- **Chalcolithic cultures** existed mainly in regions like the **Chhota Nagpur Plateau**, **Upper Gangetic Basin**, **Karnataka**, and near the banks of the **Narmada River**.
- People lived primarily in **thatched houses** made of **mud bricks** and engaged in **Jhum cultivation** (shifting agriculture).
- **Ganeshwar**, located in **Rajasthan**, was a major site of **copper artifacts** and related to the **Jodhpura culture**.
- **Pottery** was a significant development during this period, with **Black and Red Ware** being particularly notable.

Important Chalcolithic Sites

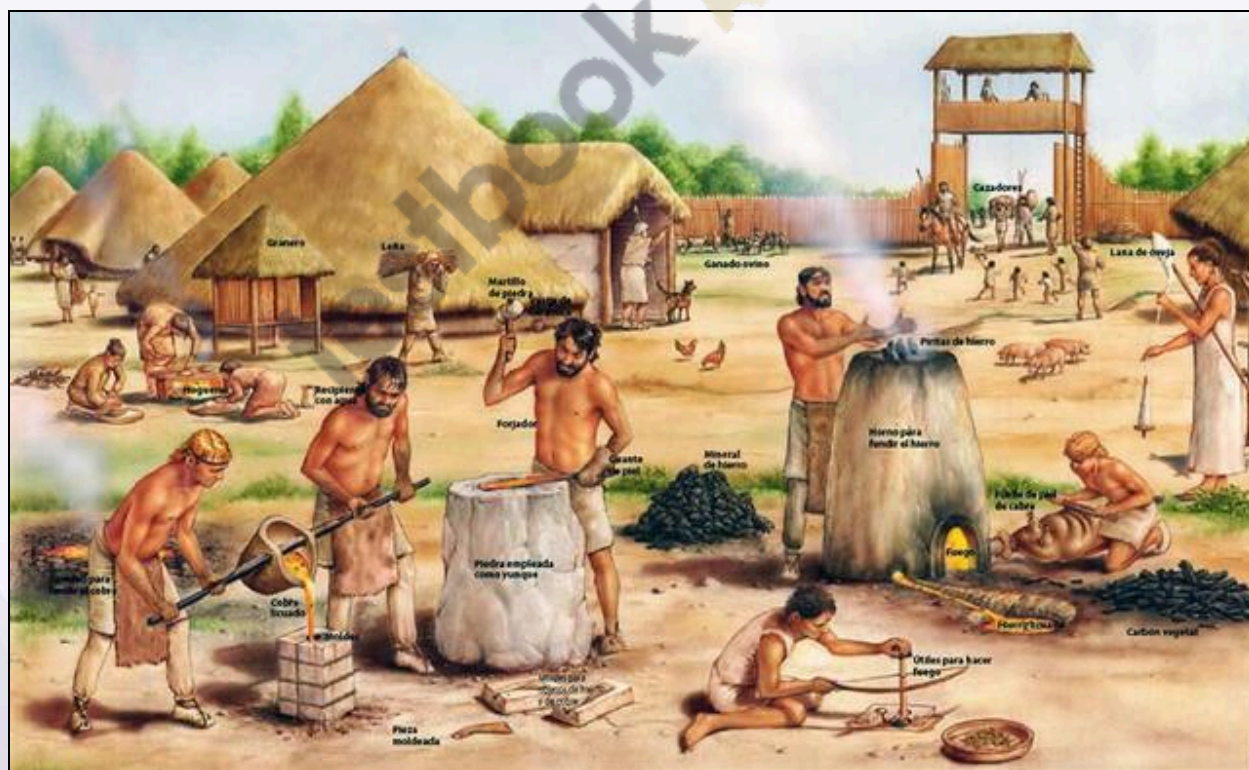
Site	Area
Ahar-Banas	Rajasthan
Kayatha	Madhya Pradesh
Malwa	Madhya Pradesh

Eran	Madhya Pradesh
Nevasa	Maharashtra
Daimabad	Maharashtra
Jorwe	Maharashtra



Key Features of Chalcolithic Culture

- **Distinctive Pottery: Black and Red Ware (BRW)** was a significant feature of Chalcolithic pottery in India. The pottery was made using the **wheel** and was brightly coloured.
- **Metals:** Tools made from **copper** and its **alloys** were common, including **knives, axes, chisels, rods, pins, and fishing hooks**.
- **Ornaments:** People made ornaments from **semi-precious stones** such as **agate, jasper, chalcedony, and carnelian**.
- **Agriculture:** Several **pulses** like **green gram, lentil, grass pea, and black gram** were cultivated. **Rice and wheat** were also grown in abundance.
- **Animal Domestication:** People domesticated **cows, sheep, goats, pigs, and buffaloes**, and they hunted **deer** for sustenance.
- **Social Structure:** The village chiefs lived in **large rectangular houses**, which indicated the beginning of **social inequalities**. This is considered one of the earliest instances of **hierarchical structures** in society.



Chalcolithic Cultures

Culture	Period	Features
Ahar-Banas	3000-1500 BC	Known for Black and Red Ware (BRW) , adjacent to the Indus Valley Civilization .
Kayatha	2400-2000 BC	Earliest agricultural settlement in Malwa region. Characterized by ceramic assemblage .
Malwa	1600-1300 BC	Navdatoli , Eran , and Nagda were key sites. Navdatoli was the largest.
Savalda	2000-1800 BC	Influenced by Mesolithic cultures in Northern Maharashtra and Harappans in Gujarat.
Jorwe	1400-700 BC	Known for black or red-painted pottery and a blade-flake industry using chalcedony .
Prabhas and Rangpur	2000-1400 BC	Derived from the Harappan Civilization , known for its Lustrous Red Ware with glossy surfaces.

Agriculture in the Chalcolithic Age

- **Major Crops:** Wheat, barley, green gram, black gram, lentils, and millets.
- **Fishing:** Played a crucial role in the economy, particularly for communities near **rivers**.
- **Jhum Cultivation:** A form of **shifting cultivation** practised by burning patches of **forests** and using the ashes as **fertilizer**.

Megalithic Culture in South India

- The **Megalithic culture** is characterized by **large stone monuments** used for **burial** and **ritualistic purposes**.
- **Iron artifacts** were commonly found in **Megalithic sites**, and **tank irrigation** systems were introduced, revolutionizing agriculture in **South India**.
- **Burial practices** were elaborate, with **stone boxes** called **cists** used for burials, and the **grave goods** reflected social status.

Megalithic Sites

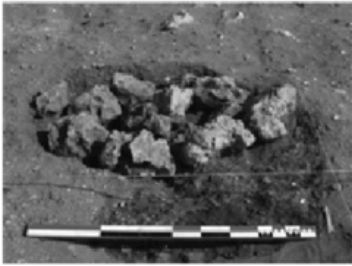
Site	Area
Junapani	Maharashtra
Adichanallur	Tamil Nadu
Brahmagiri	Karnataka
Kodumanal	Tamil Nadu
Sanganakallu	Karnataka



Burial Practices During the Stone Age

- **Burial customs** in the **Megalithic period** were highly developed, with distinct differences in **grave size** and **grave goods** based on **social status**.

- **Sangam literature** describes various **burial practices** among **South Indian tribes**, some of which persist in certain communities like the **Maria Gonds** of **Chhattisgarh**, **Bondos** of **Odisha**, and **Khasis** of **Assam**.
- The **dead** were often buried in **cists** (stone boxes) and the **burial pits** were accompanied by **four or five posts**.

Late Neolithic	Hafit	Umm an-Nar
c. 4500-3200 BC	c. 3200-2700 BC	c. 2700-2000 BC
		
		







Burials in different Harappan sites. (A) and (B) Burials at Mehrgarh site. (A) Burial in day box (B) Mehrgarh burials, pit with side chamber closed up with mud bricks. (C) and (D) Burials found at Kalibangan site. (C) Pot Burial without Skeleton. (D) Kalibangan bricklined grave. (E) A burial at Lothal site. A double burial inside brick lined grave.